

EYEWITNESS May 12, 1864

In the Trenches at Spotsylvania

During the Battle of Spotsylvania–May 8–12, 1864–Union General Winfield S. Hancock seized Confederate entrenchments known as the Mule Shoe Salient. The Confederates fought back, however, and an encounter on the northwest face of the salient on May 12 created the “Bloody Angle.” Here, in the most brutal, close-quarter fighting, blood tinged red the soil of Virginia as thousands of soldiers died.

“Infantrymen, from opposite sides of the works, climbed up and fired into the faces of their opponents; they grappled one another and attempted to drag each other across the breastworks; bayonet thrusts were made through crevices; the continuous musketry fire cut off large trees standing in the line of the works, the dead and the dying had to be flung to the rear to give room for the living, fighting ones, in the trenches and, to add to the horrors of combat, a cold, heavy rain set in and partly filled the trench, where the combatants stood, until they seemed to fairly run with blood ... the writer, who was on this field of awful combats, does not believe that human ear ever listened to a more steady and continuous roar of musketry and artillery than that which rose from the field of fierce contention, from the dawning to the day until late in the afternoon.”

JEDEDIAH HOTCHKISS, CONFEDERATE TOPOGRAPHER, ON THE “BLOODY ANGLE,” FROM *CONFEDERATE MILITARY HISTORY*, 1899

“No tongue can describe the horrors of the scene around me. Dead and dying men by scores and hundreds lie piled upon each other in promiscuous disorder. God has seen fit so far to spare me, for which I truly feel thankful. I cannot even attempt to give you a slight idea of this field of death. All around you lie the unmistakable evidences that death is doing its most frightful work. Do not worry about me. We have driven the enemy at every point, but Oh! at what a sacrifice of life ... I am more dead than alive. We have no regiment. It is so scattered that hardly a dozen can be got together. So fearful has been our